Bhutto was obsessed by an irrational need to win every election he contested by an absurd majority. He liked to think that everyone loved him, though he knew how many mullahs spoke out against his drinking and womanizing, so on the eve of elections he prohibited the sale of all alcoholic beverages and shut down every nightclub and bar in Karachi. He even stopped the construction of a huge new casino on Karachi's best beach, leaving its ugly gray shell of concrete to remind everyone of how austere and faithful a Muslim he had suddenly become. Fundamentalist Muslims of Maulana Mau-doodi's Jamaat-i-Islami Party posed the greatest challenge to Bhutto's PPP. He faced many weaker secular opponents as well, but Bhutto dismissed those as "gnats."

After Bhutto's obviously dishonest victory by over 90 percent in every district of Punjab was announced, angry crowds filled the streets of Lahore in protest, demanding that Bhutto resign for rigging the contests and burning every ballot cast for his opponents. Police were forced to open fire on Punjabi crowds, killing several people and wounding many more, yet the protests only grew louder and harsher. Several of Bhutto's most respected generals-turned-ambassadors resigned at the "disgrace" of his rigged reelection. Then Pakistan International Airlines went on strike and all its flights were canceled. Railway union workers joined in growing calls for a general strike, and the country soon came to a grinding halt. Bhutto appealed to the Saudi ambassador to ask his "friend" the king of Saudi Arabia for help, but no foreign power was willing to interfere on his behalf. So he turned to Zia, telling him to "restore order." Zia understood then that his once most popular political leader was finished. The irony of Bhutto's fall was that he could easily have won reelection and remained in power had he only allowed the electoral process to run its free course without the ridiculous rigging he demanded of his stooges. He was Pakistan's best-educated popular leader, yet he profligately squandered all his advantages and remarkable education.

After seizing power and arresting Bhutto, Zia promised to return to soldiering "soon," insisting that he was no politician, only a good soldier trying his best to save his country. Ayub Khan had said much the same thing at the start of his decade-long dictatorship, but unlike the secular Ayub, Zia planned to lead his nation with "guidance from God Almighty." He never forgot his daily prayers, and was eager to "restore order" and stop corrupt politicians from "looting" and wasting public property. He promised to be chief martial law administrator of Pakistan for no longer than ninety days, saying, "I am a very humble man."